

Blithely reshaping the world

How does Portman do it?

Gone are those wonderful, kind, crinkly faced kings, hog butchers, and urban renewal Tsars; the giants who once hired architects to build on the grand scale.

Gone are their mad, Romantic swipes that leveled cities and raised temples.

Our time, is one of little dreams and tight money. Nobody reshapes the world anymore.

No one except John Portman.

Having apparently failed to get the message, Portman goes blithely on, remaking cities on a scale that would have impressed John Nash.

In his hometown of Atlanta alone, Portman has built two hotels, two merchandise marts, five office towers, a multilevel shopping arcade and some parking garages. Portman not only designed

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all these, but also owns and manages them. Unfulfilled by all that and looking irritably around for something to occupy the rest of his time, he has also designed spectacular hotels for Los Angeles, Chicago, and San Francisco; a whole minicity, the Embarcadero Center, for San Francisco; a 23-building, 70-story mind-boggler called Renaissance Center for Detroit, and a 32-acre resort complex in Cairo, Egypt, where your yacht, leaving the Nile, can pass through the lobby of the hotel and over a water-court to your apartment door. In many of these projects, too, Portman owns a piece of the action.

Portman does it by being

his own patron, his own Tsar: he thinks up a project; raises money; hires himself to design it. Some think he is the wave of the architectural future. Now he's written a book, "The Architect as Developer, (McGraw-Hill, \$22.95) with the urban designer and writer Jonathan Barnett.

Portman shows us the Portman he wants us to see; the Portman who makes other architects — starved for commissions — gnash their teeth. What galls is not only that he has so much financial clout, but that he got it not by erecting dreary Prudential Centers to please bankers, but instead by realizing the mad dreams of an architectural fantasist. At a time when new hotels were

klutzy slabs with dark corridors down the middle of each floor and identical rooms on both sides — the length of the building often a function of the most efficient use of maids — Portman put up hotels that had 20-story skylit atriums; where all-glass elevators, having escaped from their closets, climbed the walls like glistening cockroaches; where trees and fountains pirouetted below in Busby Berkley formations.

Like any showman, Portman feels the need to top himself and his latest, the Peachtree Plaza in Atlanta — of course, it's the world's tallest hotel — is a mirrored glass cylinder of guest rooms rising from a concrete base of restaurants and convention rooms. Where the round glass peg drops through the square concrete hole in one of those spaces no one but Portman would conceive. Guests sip their cocktails on islands in a lagoon between vast columns that recall a porticoed, mossy southern manse.

Characteristically, Portman as developer went ahead with this King-Ludwig extravaganza even after a marketing study recommended against it. Characteristically, if you believe the book, the public loves it. Caroming among his architecture firm, Portman Associates; his development firm, Portman Properties; his contract furnishing business; his restaurant corporation and others; Portman, his book says, remains sane by accepting few phone calls and attending few meetings. He does all his own designing — easy to believe — even the furniture. He admires Frank Lloyd Wright (the Guggenheim)

and Tivoli Gardens in Copenhagen.

As the above may suggest, this isn't a book with a lot of intellectual meat. It's a bastard cross between a campaign biography and a coffee-table confection. Lavish with photographs and praise, it tells little about how Portman accomplishes what he does or what meaning it has for the architectural profession. We're thrown teasing morsels about the wonderfully named Dallas financier, Trammell Crow, who helped Portman take off. But there's little detail and the writing is perfunctory.

Jonathan Barnett ends the book with a plea that architects follow Portman's example and become experts in real estate. In the absence of patrons, only the architect-developer can really create good environment. He says.

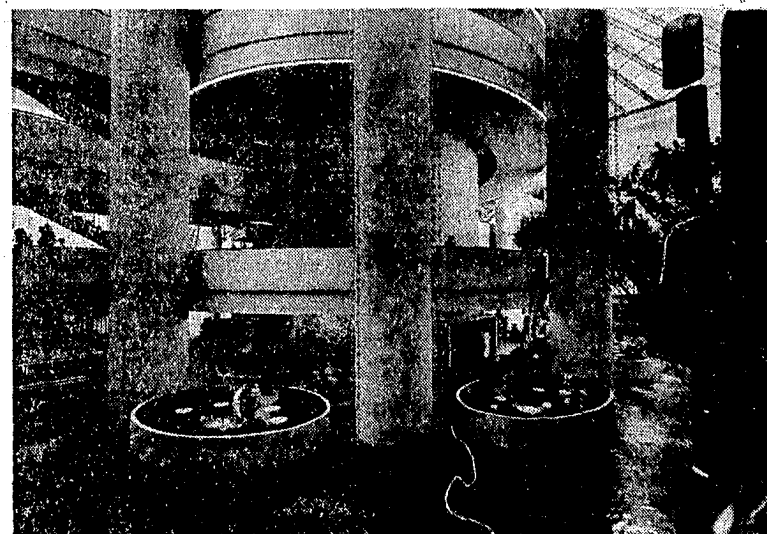
"Portman has demonstrated that spaces of real architectural distinction can be an important factor in a good commercial investment. By demonstrating the mutual reinforcement between architecture and real estate, Portman has shown that architects ought to know a great deal more about finance and that developers, lenders, and investors have a lot to learn about architecture...

"Architects who consider real estate finance to be crass and vulgar and beneath the notice of an artist should ask themselves if they're not cut off from some of the important roots of their art."

Who can quarrel? But we're still left wondering how Portman did it.



World's tallest hotel, Peachtree Plaza in Atlanta, is John Portman's latest venture. Glass peg of guest rooms drops through concrete hole of function rooms. Where they meet is glass-roofed atrium.



Inside atrium guests sip cocktails on islands in lagoon beside columns that support the guest-room tower above.